

GENESYS QUICKSTART GUIDE

This document is for quickly conveying the core concepts of the Narrative Dice System to players. Bringing players in from other role-playing games can be difficult because people love to stick with what they know best. If you are a player reading this, then someone you know wants to run a Genesys game for you. This person thinks that you will have a lot of fun trying this system.

Genesys gives us ways to tell our stories we have not had before. It is a multi-axis dice mechanic, letting characters succeed at a cost or fail but still attain something positive. It also allows for epic triumphs

and story-bending despair. Anything new can be scary or intimidating, or maybe cause one to just feel a little bit wary. But hopefully you trust that the person giving this document to you is capable of telling a fun and engaging story regardless of the system, so just give it a shot.

Finally, this quick start guide does not constitute all the rules needed for play. Your GM should hopefully have a good grasp of them already. This is intended solely to on-board new players quickly and show the minimum necessary concepts to get started.

WEIRD DICE

Where are the numbers? We don't need numbers. We don't compare results to a series of tables or try to do arithmetic in the middle of a combat encounter. These new dice show us the story beyond simple binary success or failure. There are three of each type and are separated into positive and negative dice. Positive dice representing your character's raw ability, their skill training, and other boons from circumstance or the environment. Negative dice represent the inherent obstacles, opponent's training, or hindrances from circumstances or the environment.

POSITIVE DICE

The three types of positive dice are Ability, Proficiency, and Boost. Having more of any of them when rolling is always good.

ABILITY

The green Ability die represents basic skill or aptitude and forms the base of any skill check.



PROFICIENCY

The yellow Proficiency die represents advanced skill or training. The only way to use a Proficiency die is if an Ability die get upgraded.



BOOST

The blue Boost die represents additional benefits from lucky circumstances, careful planning, and help from friends.



NEGATIVE DICE

The three types of negative dice are Difficulty, Challenge, and Setback. You want to mitigate how many of these dice you have to roll. Although, it is through these dice that the most interesting complications can occur.

DIFFICULTY DIE

The purple Difficulty die represents basic obstacles and the inherent difficulty of performing a task.



CHALLENGE DIE

The red Challenge die represents more extreme adversity or advanced training of a foe. To get a Challenge die in your dice pool a Difficulty die must be upgraded.



SETBACK

The black Setback die represents hindrances from unlucky circumstances, environmental hazards, or a foe actively working against you.



BUILDING THE DICE POOL

When the GM asks for a skill check you'll roll positive dice based on one of your characteristics and one of your skills, and some negative dice based on the difficulty of the task. The GM will tell you which negative dice (◆ and ◆) to use. Every skill your character has is linked with one of the six base characteristics; Brawn, Agility, Cunning, Intellect, Willpower, and Presence. For instance, the Athletics skill is linked with the Brawn characteristic. To determine which positive dice to roll look at both values for the skill and the characteristic. Whichever is higher is the number of green Ability ◆ dice you start with. The lower value is the number of green Ability ◆ dice that get upgraded to yellow Proficiency ◆ dice. So if your character has a Brawn of 3 and an Athletics of 2 then you'll roll ◆◆◆. Additionally, if they instead had a Brawn of 2 and an Athletics of 3 the dice would be the same.

Once you know the dice coming from your character's skill and the dice coming from the difficulty, the GM may add blue Boost ■ dice or black Setback ■ dice based on circumstances. Frequently, you may find that a Talent your character possesses will also add blue Boost ■ dice or even remove black Setback ■ dice.

INCREASING AND DECREASING

Increasing and Decreasing nearly always refers to the difficulty of the task. Any increases or decreases happen before any pool modifications. Most of the time these increases or decreases will not be visible to you, the player, since the GM should apply these before informing you of the difficulty. However, some abilities can call for an increase or decrease. Increases add a number purple Difficulty ◆ dice equal to the increase. For instance if a task has a difficulty of Average (◆◆) increasing it once makes it Hard (◆◆◆). Decreasing, of course, does the opposite. If you have a task with a difficulty Hard (◆◆◆) decreasing it makes it Average (◆◆).

MODIFYING THE DICE POOL

Some game effects can modify the dice pool. There's four basic ways in which the pool can be modified: Adding, Upgrading, Downgrading, and Removing. When multiple effects apply, they apply in that order.

ADDING

Adding dice is easy. Just add in whatever the effect says. This is usually going to be blue Boost ■ or black Setback ■ dice.

UPGRADING

When effects call for an Upgrade they will usually specify if the skill or the difficulty is being upgraded. If the skill is Upgraded then the positive dice are affected. If the difficulty is Upgraded then the negative dice are affected. When Upgrading you will take a green Ability ◆ or purple Difficulty ◆ die and change it to either a yellow Proficiency ◆ or red Challenge ◆ die respectively. In short ◆ -> ◆ or ◆ -> ◆. If there is not a green Ability ◆ or purple Difficulty ◆ die to upgrade then add a green Ability ◆ or purple Difficulty die ◆ instead.

DOWNGRADING

Downgrading works in the opposite direction than Upgrading. Just like Upgrading, the effect should specify if the skill or the difficulty is being affected. When Downgrading you will take a yellow Proficiency ◆ or red Challenge ◆ die and change it to a green Ability ◆ or purple Difficulty ◆ die respectively. In short ◆ -> ◆ or ◆ -> ◆. If there is not a yellow Proficiency ◆ or red Challenge ◆ die to downgrade then don't change anything.

REMOVING

Just like adding, removing is easy but opposite. Whatever die is referenced by the effect to be removed from the pool is taken out and not rolled. If no such dice are in the pool then nothing happens.

INTERPRETING THE RESULTS

After you have rolled the dice you will need to read the results to determine the outcome. The results will determine success or failure, but also any additional side effects that may occur, good or bad.

SUCCESS AND FAILURE

Success  symbols are canceled by Failure  symbols. If there are remaining Success  symbols in the result pool then the check has succeeded. If there are no Success  symbols or there are Failure  symbols remaining then the check has failed. But success or failure is not the whole story and you will see how Triumph  symbols and Despair  symbols will further affect things in a bit.

ADVANTAGE AND THREAT

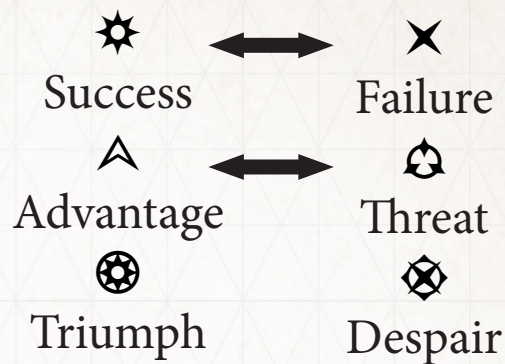
Advantage  symbols are canceled by Threat  symbols. Each of these symbols can be used to give minor benefits or negative side effects. How exactly they affect the situation depends entirely on the situation. Many times they may simply have mechanical effects such as healing or causing Strain, but they can also affect the narrative in small ways. For instance, if your character is attempting to climb a wall, the GM may call for you

STORY POINTS

Story Points represent that extra edge your characters have from being the protagonists of the story. They also represent the fact that as protagonists, bad things happen to them as well. At the start of each session the GM will put a Story Point in the Player Story Point Pool for each player and one in a separate GM Story Point Pool. When a Story Point from either side is spent it goes into the other pool. You can think of Story Points as moving to another pool or as being flipped to the other side. It just depends on what kind of tokens your GM is using to represent the points.

USING A STORY POINT

As a player, you can use, flip, or spend a Story Point to accomplish many things. This is your character calling on *deus ex machina*, plot armor, or some other such trope to help them succeed or survive.



to make an Athletics skill check. If you succeed at the check but have Threat  symbols remaining the GM could say that when your character makes it to the top their backpack gets caught, tearing the straps, and causing it fall down where your character just came from.

TRIUMPH AND DESPAIR

Triumph  symbols also count as a Success  symbol and Despair  symbols also count as a Failure  symbol. The Success  and Failure  parts of Triumph  and Despair  can be canceled, but not the extra effects of each. They also do not cancel each other. This means you can end up with both Triumph  and Despair  in the final results. These extra effects are like super Advantage  and Threat . They give major boons or serious hindrances either mechanically or narratively.

TALENTS AND ABILITIES

There are many talents and archetype/species abilities that are powered by Story Points. Check your character sheet to see if your character has any of these.

HELPING HAND

You can spend a Story Point to upgrade any check your character makes. When you do this, a green Ability  die becomes a yellow Proficiency  die. If you don't have any green Ability  dice in your pool to be upgraded then you add one green Ability  die instead. Beware though, the GM may spend their Story Points to do the same thing with NPCs.

RAISING THE STAKES

The GM can spend a Story Point to upgrade the difficulty of any check a PC makes. When they do this, a purple Difficulty ♦ die becomes a red Challenge ● die. If there are no purple Difficulty ♦ dice in the pool then one purple Difficulty ♦ die is added instead. Keep in mind that you as a player can spend your Story Points to do the same thing to NPCs!

ALTER THE NARRATIVE

The final thing that you can use Story Points for are to introduce facts or additional details into the narrative. For instance, your character sheet may not have specified that you have 50 feet of rope, but if you spend a Story Point it is possible you do after all. Spending Story Points like this is always subject to GM approval and should make sense for the characters and the story.

COMBAT ENCOUNTERS

When your characters get involved in a situation where every decision matters and lives may be on the line, your GM will likely shift the game-play from Narrative to Structured. The most common Structured Encounter is combat. Social Encounters are also a thing, but are less frequently used and are not covered in this guide. You will know you have begun a combat encounter because your GM will ask everyone for an Initiative roll. They will then assign initiative slots based on everyone's roll, including the NPCs. Then combat will start with PCs and NPCs taking turns in the available slots. Once one side has been completely removed from the encounter, either through exceeding Wound or Strain thresholds, the encounter ends.

INITIATIVE

The encounter Initiative is determined by each character making a Cool or Vigilance check with a **Simple** (-) difficulty, meaning no difficulty dice are used. Which skill is used is determined by the GM based on the circumstances. For the most part, if the characters are aware that conflict is afoot then Cool is used and if they are surprised then Vigilance is used. Once everyone has their results the GM will create PC and NPC slots.

TAKE YOUR TURN

Your specific initiative roll does not determine when you can act in a turn, it determines when any PC may act. It is expected that players will agree on who will act in any given PC slot. The GM will determine which NPC will act in any given NPC slot. Additionally, on the next round everyone may act in completely different slots. This gives everyone some tactical choices in that it could cause a character to act twice in a row.

On your turn you have many options. You get one Action, one free Maneuver, and a reasonable number of Incidentals.

INCIDENTALS

Incidental are small operations that require very little effort to perform. There is no mechanical limit to the number of Incidentals a character can perform, but your GM may cut you off if you push the boundaries of what makes sense. Some examples incidentals are speaking a short sentence or two, dropping a held item or character, and making small movements like peeking around a corner.

MANEUVERS

Maneuvers are the things you can do that are not as simple as an Incidental or a complex as an Action. They are activities that do not require a skill check; you just do them. Your GM should provide you the exhaustive list of Maneuvers, but for the most part you will use Maneuvers to move from one place to another, drawing or holstering a weapon, standing up or lying down, or taking your time to aim at a target. You get one free Maneuver on each of your turns. You can take up to one additional Maneuver by either suffering 2 strain or using your Action. No matter what, you can only perform two Maneuvers on your turn, with few exceptions.

ACTIONS

Actions are those complex activities that almost always require a skill check. Your action is used to shoot a gun or swing a sword at a target, jump a chasm, hack a computer, or cast a spell. These checks will use all the rules you learned in the Building The Dice Pool section.

RANGE BANDS

This is the part that most people have trouble with. Instead of tightly defined hexes or squares. Genesys uses relative distances. This can be a bit odd to keep track of if you are coming from a game that relies on a grid, but if you keep in mind that Genesys is more narrative focused and let yourself be comfortable with the cinematic nature you will have a much better time.

ENGAGED

Engaged is the Range Band representing someone standing right next to you or about within arm's reach. This is the range in which most melee or brawling combat occurs.

SHORT

Short range is up to several meters. Most people treat it as about 6 meters or 20 feet. It is the distance you can have a normal volume conversation.

MEDIUM

Medium range is described as several dozen meters away. Most people will treat this as 60 meters or almost 200 feet. At this distance people will have to talk loudly at each other to be heard. Thrown weapons will rarely reach this distance and hitting a target with a pistol this far away is very difficult.

LONG

Long range is at least twice as far as Medium range. To move from Medium to Long range requires two Maneuvers. Two people could only hear each other at this range by shouting very loudly.

EXTREME

This is typically the farthest range you will encounter in a Genesys game. It is at least twice as far as Long range. Moving from Long to Extreme range requires two maneuvers. Hearing someone at this range is impossible. Only vehicle mounted weapons or power sniper rifles can even operate at Extreme range.

CONTACT INFORMATION

If you have any feedback or find any mistakes please let me know. I am Scott Zumwalt. You can find me on reddit as /u/DrainSmith, Discord as DrainSmith#0001, or email at scott.zumwalt@gmail.com.

I also urge you to join the Genesys RPG Community through our various social media sites:

Discord: <http://discord.gg/GVpYH8x9YB>

Facebook: <https://www.facebook.com/groups/GenesysRPG>

Reddit: <https://www.reddit.com/r/genesysrpg/>